

Belle (Chaoyi) Zhang

Ph.D. Candidate — Organizational Theory, Strategy and Entrepreneurship
Tepper School of Business, Carnegie Mellon University
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Education

Carnegie Mellon University, Tepper School of Business, Pittsburgh, PA

Ph.D. Candidate, Organizational Theory, Strategy and Entrepreneurship, Sep 2021 – May 2027 (expected)

Committee: Brandy Aven (Chair), Oliver Hahl, Carrington Motley, Trevor Young-Hyman(External), David Hsu (External)

Carnegie Mellon University, Tepper School of Business, Pittsburgh, PA

M.Sc., Organizational Behavior and Theory, May 2023

University of Chicago, Chicago, IL

Chicago Booth Research Professionals Program, 2019 – 2021

University of Chicago, Chicago, IL

M.Sc., Quantitative Methods and Social Analysis, 2018 – 2019

University of Wisconsin–Madison, Madison, WI

B.Sc., Economics; B.A., Sociology (Concentration in Analysis and Research), 2011 – 2014

Research Interests

Innovation; Search Strategy; Commercialization; Drug Discovery; Entrepreneurship; Decision-Making Under Uncertainty; Social Network Analysis; Two-Sided Matching.

Dissertation

Zhang, C. **Innovation Without a Problem: Repurposing of Existing Capabilities**

This dissertation investigates when, how and why organizations engage in solution-driven search, a form of search process that is not motivated by a specific problem but rather by the potential to repurpose existing capabilities.

1. **Solutions in Search of Problems: When Ill-Defined Evaluation Pays** (Formation)
— *Job Market Paper*
2. **Positioned to Repurpose: Who Converts an AI-Surfaced Match** (Conversion) —
Job Market Paper
3. **Keeping What You Find: Appropriability as Incentive** (Appropriation)

Working Papers

Aven, B., Zhang, C. & Shen, R. **Complementary Capitalists: Venture Capital Syndication Groups in China.** *Under review at Administrative Science Quarterly.*

Zhang, C., Motley, C. & Aven, B. **The Problem with Fear of Missing Out (FoMO): Peer Influence on VC Decision-Making.** *Ready to Submit at Strategic Management Journal.*

Zhang, C., Aven, B. **Reversing the Pitch: Field Data on Founder–VC Fit and a Startup-First Matching Platform** *Field Data Collection*

Honors & Awards

- PNC Presidential Fellowship, Tepper School of Business, Carnegie Mellon University, 2025–26
- Best PhD Paper Award (Nominee), Strategic Management Society (SMS) Annual Conference, 2025

Conference Presentations

- **9th Annual Wharton Innovation Doctoral Symposium**, Philadelphia, PA, 2026.
- **East Coast Doctoral Conference**, New York University, NY, 2025.
- **Strategic Management Society (SMS) Annual Conference**, San Francisco, CA, 2025.
- **Academy of Management (OMT Consortium)**, Boston, MA, 2025. *Innovation Without a Problem: The Antecedents of Solution-Driven Search in Drug Discovery.*
- **Duke Strategy Doctoral Conference**, Durham, NC, 2024. *The Problem with Fear of Missing Out: Peer Effects on Imitation in VC Decision-Making.*
- **Value Creation, Capture & Sharing in Organizational Networks Conference**, Tilburg University, Netherlands, 2023. *Replicating Network Advantage: Exit Mechanisms and the Formation of Structural-Role-Complementary Syndicates in Venture Capital Investment.*
- **Academy of Management (Symposium)**, Boston, MA, 2023. *Constrained or Free? How Networks Enable and Reduce Path-Dependent Behavior.*

Teaching Experience

Instructor of Record — Carnegie Mellon University, Tepper School of Business

- Introduction to Organizational Behavior (strategic-management focus), Undergraduate, Summer 2025 — evaluation 4.95/5.0

Teaching Assistant — Carnegie Mellon University, Tepper School of Business

- Managing Organizations and Networks (MBA), Prof. B. Aven, 2023–2025
- Introduction to Entrepreneurship (MBA), Prof. J. Oh, 2024
- People Analytics (MBA), Prof. B. Aven, 2023–2024
- Venture Capital & the Finance of Innovation (MBA), Prof. M. Denes, 2024
- Organizational Learning (MBA), Prof. L. Argote, 2023–2024
- Strategic Management and Innovation (MBA), Prof. O. Hahl, 2023

Research Experience

Research Professional — University of Chicago, Booth School of Business (2019–2021)

- Tax Planning Knowledge Diffusion via the Labor Market (for Prof. J. Gallemore)
- The Effect of Corporate Taxation on Bank Transparency: Evidence from Loan Loss Provisions (for Prof. J. Gallemore)
- Do Conflict-of-Interest Disclosures Work? Evidence from Citations in Medical Journals (for Prof. M. Maximillian)

Technical Skills & Coursework

Programming: Python (Pandas, NumPy, PyTorch, Scikit-Learn), R, Stata.

Doctoral coursework: Dynamic Social Network Analysis; Introduction to Deep Learning; Probabilistic Graphical Models; Machine Learning for Structured Prediction; ML with Large Datasets; Machine Learning with Graphs.

Service & Professional Affiliations

Reviewer: Academy of Management (STR, 2025; ENT, 2025)

Member: Strategic Management Society (2023–present); Academy of Management (2023–present)

References

Brandy L. Aven (Dissertation Chair)

Associate Professor of Organization Theory and Entrepreneurship (with tenure), Carnegie Mellon University
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Oliver Hahl

Associate Professor of Organization Theory and Entrepreneurship (with tenure), Carnegie Mellon University
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Carrington Motley

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David H. Hsu (External Committee Member)

Jeffrey A. Keswin Professor; Richard A. Sapp Professor; Professor of Management
Director, Jerome Fisher Program in Management & Technology, The Wharton School, University of Pennsylvania
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Trevor Young-Hyman

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